

Lesson 10: Powerful Conversations

Alexis Hornbuckle

When it comes to communication, there are two areas that can make or break your career: how well you communicate with your leader (or upper management), and how well you handle conflict – that is to say, how you handle difficult conversations with a colleague or team member.

Ever been around someone who didn't handle difficult conversations well? Anything that had the slightest bit of emotion around it, and within five minutes it was like a bomb went off in the conversation? Maybe this is you – does just the thought of having a difficult conversation make your heart race?

How about those you know who couldn't communicate well with their leaders? Their leader never knew what they were working on, or they felt conversations with this person were always negative, a never-ending string of problems.

How far do *any* of these people go in their careers?

Not as far as those who master the art of powerful conversations!

Let's start with your leader. Think about your current leader. On a scale of 1-10, how well do you feel you communicate with them currently? Do you know your current leader's communication style?

There are three keys to remember when communicating with your leader: right channel, right timing, right message.

In addition, there are a few best practices to keep in mind with your leader.

Be positive! This one is important. Leaders quickly learn which team members are solution-oriented who are looking for the positive in each situation, as opposed to those who are a Negative Nancy.

Be prepared. Always be prepared when you take your leader's time. Do you know what you plan to discuss? Is there something important you need to show them? Plan this out in advance, so your meetings are well-organized and productive.

Bring solutions. Problems are real, but whenever bringing an issue to your leader, also present some options for solving the problem if you're able. Your leader may have thoughts of her/his own, but they will appreciate you bringing options to the table.

Be open to feedback. Be coachable! This one is a must for any growth in your career.

Sound doable? Let's learn!